NASM VIRTUAL COACHING SPECIALIST (VCS)

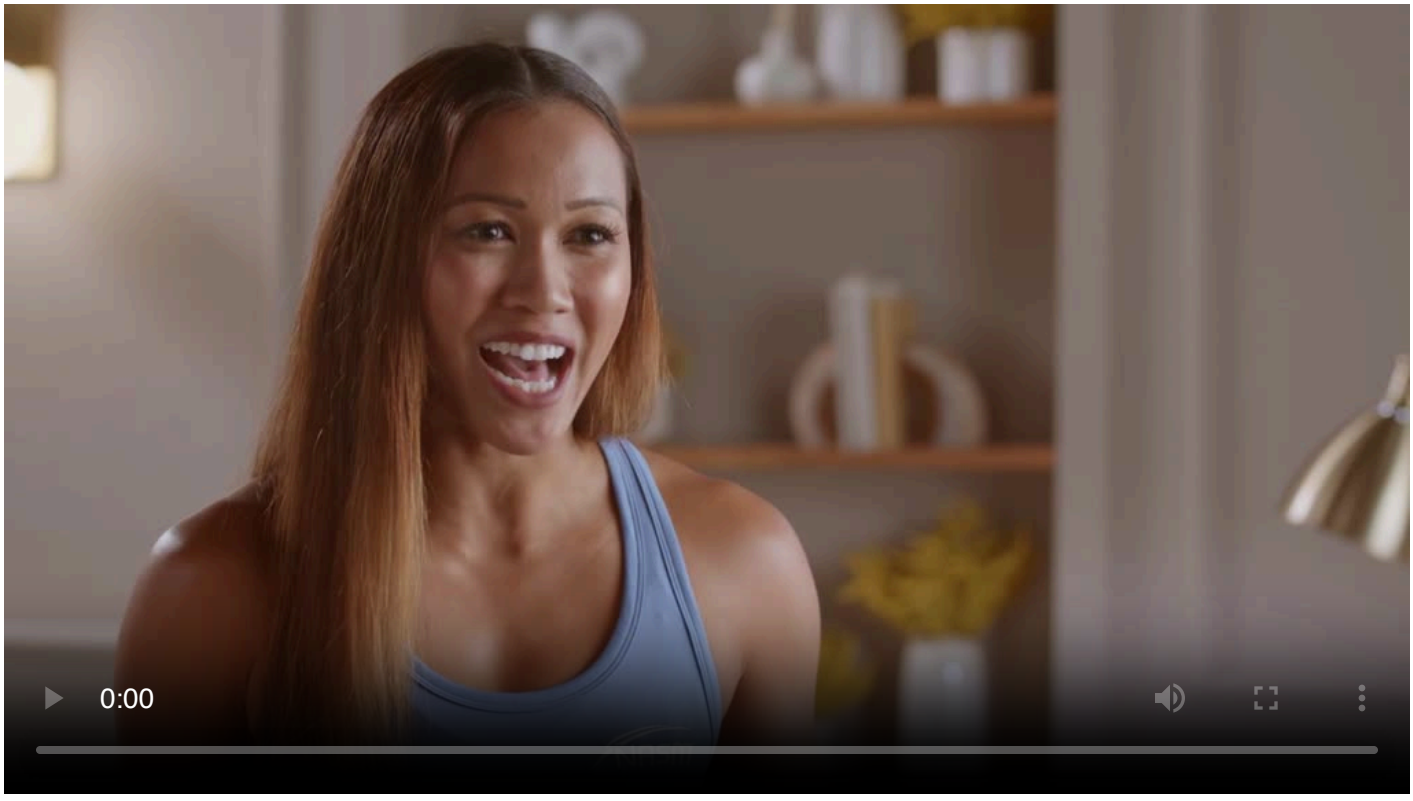
Chapter 1: Introduction to Virtual Coaching

National Academy of Sports Medicine — Evidence-Based Telehealth Curriculum

Chapter 1Introduction to Virtual Coaching
Lesson 1Welcome to NASM Virtual Coaching

Welcome to NASM Virtual Coaching

The NASM Virtual Coaching course is an immersive online experience that equips fitness professionals with the skills, tools, and strategies to operate a virtual coaching business. Throughout this course, professionals will learn how to foster an engaging and effective online relationship with their clients, leveraging various technologies. This course uses the virtual environment to provide the skills and knowledge to address topics including scope of practice, business planning, technology requirements, communication strategies, conducting virtual fitness assessments, implementing virtual coaching sessions, and fundamental business operations.



Programmatic Objectives

At the end of this course, you will:

- **Develop** the key components of a business plan required to launch a virtual coaching business.
- **Conduct** and modify fitness assessments using the virtual environment with clients.
- **Coach** and cue clients in a virtual environment.
- **Develop** effective virtual coaching strategies for different client types and fitness goals.
- **Identify** virtual services fitness professionals require to scale and sustain a virtual coaching business.
- **Differentiate** virtual sales and marketing strategies used to grow a virtual coaching business.

Your Course

The NASM Virtual Coaching course has been divided into 4 sections. Designed for the fitness professional looking to leverage the virtual environment, this course uses a step-by-step approach to address the skills and knowledge required to launch a successful virtual coaching business.

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Earning your Credential

To earn your NASM Virtual Coaching Specialist designation, the only requirement is passing the Final Exam. Please be advised that you have 365 days from your date of purchase to pass your Final Exam.

Final Exam Information:

- Passing Score: 70% or higher
- Questions: 100 multiple-choice
- Time Limit: 90 Minutes
- Max Attempts: 3
- Exam Expiration: 365 days from date of purchase
- NASM CEUs: NASM 1.5

Let's Get Started

We at the National Academy of Sports Medicine are here to support you, so do not hesitate to call on us if you need some help.

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It's time to get started. Are you ready?

Virtual coaching provides fitness professionals with the ability to train more clients, avoid geographical limitations, and increase revenue, but it comes with certain disadvantages. Without a physical training space and regular in-person sessions, fitness professionals often find it difficult differentiating themselves to attract new clients, developing or maintaining trust and communication, and monitoring compliance to avoid injuries and ensure outcomes. The *NASM Virtual Coaching* course provides fitness professionals with the necessary business, physical training, behavioral, and technological knowledge necessary to build a thriving virtual training business.

Learning Objectives

After completing this chapter, the NASM Virtual Coach will have the ability to do the following:

- **Define** the role of a virtual coach.
- **Identify** potential opportunities from offering coaching services within a virtual environment.
- **Determine** the different client types who would benefit from virtual coaching services.
- **Summarize** the professional qualifications of a virtual coach.
- **Explain** professional scope of practice of a virtual coach.

Introduction

Not long ago, the fitness industry was centered around locations that included a built-in client base for fitness professionals: the gym. The current landscape of the fitness industry looks much different, with demand at an all-time high. According to the 2019 IHRSA Health Club Consumer Report, more than 71 million people in the United States reported being a member of a fitness center, gym, or studio in 2018 (Rodriguez, 2019).

To accommodate such growth, the number of gyms, fitness centers, studios, and fitness professionals who run and staff these establishments has exploded. The Bureau of Labor Statistics (2020) projects 15% growth in employment for fitness trainers and instructors from 2019 to 2029 (**Figure: Employment Growth Within the Fitness Industry**), creating a level of competition that forces fitness professionals to become creative with strategies for setting their business apart.



FIGUREEmployment Growth Within the Fitness Industry



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For fitness professionals looking to diversify, sustain, and grow their **book of business** (list of clients), offering virtual coaching services can help positively impact these efforts. Recent events have forced clients to seek at-home fitness solutions. Combined with the continuous rise of chronic health conditions like obesity, diabetes, heart disease, and other lifestyle-influenced conditions, this has created an environment in which the demand for adaptable fitness and nutrition coaching services is high.

With the ability to book any client, anywhere, at any time, virtual coaches can make a substantial impact on the health and wellness of clients at practically any fitness level. On any given day, a virtual coach can meet with a weight-loss client in California, train a youth athlete in Michigan, and a lead a group fitness class in Louisiana, all before lunch. There has never been a better or more exciting time for certified fitness professionals to build a virtual coaching business.

Coach's Corner

Offering virtual coaching services may be incredibly overwhelming at first. However, fitness professionals should not let the fear of the unknown stop them from taking a positive step toward the game-changing world of virtual coaching. To avoid feeling overwhelmed about the requirements needed

to transition the various services offered, the fitness professional should focus on immediate steps they can take to help facilitate this process. For example, before offering virtual coaching sessions with new or existing clients, they should begin by leveraging technology to track and communicate client progress.

Book of business

The professional’s list of clients.

The Virtual Coach

Virtual coaches provide live, one-on-one programming through virtual means, such as video, chat, and livestreams, while integrating other communication technologies such as e-mail, file sharing, etc. Much like in-person fitness professionals, virtual coaches meet with clients on a set schedule, work together to set goals and milestones, and discuss progress and potential adjustments to programming.



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While predesigned, one-size-fits-all workouts may be provided, this approach should complement the virtual experience not replace it. When executed effectively, the virtual coaching experience allows the client and virtual coach a more accessible way to work together to achieve goals in a healthy, attainable, realistic, and safe manner.

History of Virtual Coaching



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While the concept of virtual coaching is relatively new, the use of technology to bring personalized and more private fitness solutions to the masses is not. Currently, virtual coaching is a natural evolution of the virtual training system, which used **emerging technology** to deliver personal trainer-like services to those who experienced barriers to frequenting a fitness center.

> *"With the advent of smartphones and affordable **sensing technologies**, the possibility to automate several of the functions of a personal trainer emerged... [allowing] a person to manage their own personal fitness program while integrating close monitoring, sports science knowledge, and motivational aspects (Lowe & ÓLaighin, 2012)."*

Using a combination of smartphone apps, sensing technologies, and image processing devices to gather data before, during, and after workouts, virtual coaches can collect and use client data to coach their clients to success. However, while these technologies make it easy for individuals to track fitness data on their own, they lack the ability to address many of the unforeseen obstacles otherwise addressed by a virtual coach.



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Virtual coach

A professional who provides live, one-on-one programming through virtual means such as video, chat, and livestreams while integrating other communication technologies such as e-mail, file sharing, etc.

Emerging technology

New technologies currently developing that are expected to have a significant social and/or economic impact.

Sensing technologies

Devices that use sensors to detect and record physical or biological information and often are referred to as biometric wearables.

Trends in Virtual Coaching

The limits to virtual coaching extend beyond personal training and nutrition coaching. Remote sessions are now considered a mainstream way of doing business and have become part of the service offerings provided by fitness professionals looking to grow and expand their reach in the industry. Because many technologies used to operate as a virtual coach are now user-friendly for both the client and coach, it is now common to see fitness professionals adopting and integrating virtual strategies within their current in-person training methods, thereby creating a hybrid approach to training and coaching their conventional client base. A virtual coach should assess trends and emerging technologies to determine if they are right for the services they offer and, most importantly, for their client. Included are a few trends in the fitness industry's virtual workspace that have helped define and differentiate the degrees of operating as a virtual coach.

Predesigned Workouts

Predesigned workouts, sometimes called canned workouts, are already a part of the fitness professional's arsenal of tools used to train or coach clients. However, the strategies used to leverage these have drastically evolved in the virtual space. Whether provided as a free preview, included as part of a virtual coaching package, or available for purchase, the ability to provide predesigned workouts via e-mail, file sharing, or website is a great way to show prospective and current clients the fitness professional's ability to program for various fitness goals. Plus, predesigned workouts can also help virtual coaches expand their book of business or create supplemental income. And while convenient for coaches and clients alike, virtual coaches should avoid using predesigned workouts as a means to minimize or otherwise substitute for real-time interactions during a virtual coaching session with a client.

One-on-One Personal Training and Group Fitness

It has become increasingly easy for fitness professionals to acquire and/or transition many of their clients to virtual sessions with the availability of emerging technologies. Audio/video has become widely used to facilitate real-time communication, even for those who use Smartphones and computers to conduct business with clients who might not be as technologically savvy. Finding more efficient ways to coach more clients should be a goal for fitness professionals looking to grow their abilities while providing an array of service offerings to their clients. Virtual sessions provide fitness professionals with the ability to enjoy high-quality interactions with their clients regardless of location. Whether the need is to provide

one-on-one training or instruct a group fitness session, fitness professionals are leveraging the virtual environment while upholding the benefits clients would otherwise have with them in person (**Figure: Virtual Personal Training and Group Fitness Instruction**).



FIGUREVirtual Personal Training and Group Fitness Instruction

One-on-one training, delivered virtually and in real time, provides clients with the freedom to access a coach that they know, like, and trust from the comfort and privacy of their own home, creating a client-coach relationship that supports successful, long-lasting change.

Virtual coaching for group fitness instruction provides flexibility for clients who cannot make it to an in-person class due to closures, proximity, or personal preference. Various methods of streaming will now accommodate numerous participants in one class, providing virtual coaches with the ability to encourage interaction, build community, and increase accountability.

Check-Ins

Scheduling regular client check-ins is a crucial step to ensuring client engagement as they continue to work toward their fitness goals. However, it may become increasingly difficult to require clients to allocate the time required to have these check-in discussions with their coaches. For fitness professionals, integrating virtual technologies to help make it more feasible for their clients to check in, while remote, is an effective way to hold clients accountable to their fitness goals. In a 2017 study aimed at discovering how fitness technology impacts behavior change, researchers found that:

> *"Interventions that included established behavior change techniques were associated with greater increases in physical activity and subsequent weight loss than those that did not. Specifically, self-regulatory behavior change techniques such as goal setting, self-monitoring, and social support were associated with better outcomes (Sullivan & Lachman, 2017)."*

Fitness professionals use goal setting as a tool to motivate clients, and the exercise is especially important in a virtual environment where another key factor for success, social support, is not physically present. Goals are often tracked in a health and fitness app, but virtual check-ins complement virtual coaching by adding accountability, consistency, and a sense of support to the client/coach relationship.

Nutrition Coaching

Virtual nutrition coaching allows fitness professionals to connect with clients in new and useful ways. Using a virtual environment, a nutrition coach has the ability to take a virtual tour of a client's kitchen to review pantry items, discuss food labels, check snack options on-hand, talk about using certain kitchen tools to maximize efficiency and meal prep, or to brainstorm alternatives based on what a client already has in the kitchen. Having the ability to leverage technology to get a peek at a client's living space has become a powerful strategy to helping clients identify obstacles and barriers otherwise overlooked when trying to improve eating habits.

Try This

Next time a client cannot make an in-person session work, reschedule with a virtual session instead of cancelling altogether. Having the ability to provide clients an alternative option can help address and overcome client objections.

Clients Seeking Virtual Coaching

Virtual coaching is a benefit for existing and prospective clients alike, but it will not be for every everyone. Fitness professionals looking to offer virtual coaching to new or existing clients will need to understand whether a client will be successful engaging with them in a virtual environment compared to traditional in-person training and/or coaching methods. During conversations with existing or prospective clients, it is important to ask them questions that will help determine their interest level in being trained or coached using a virtual environment and/or engaging with various virtual technologies. In most cases, the fitness professional may uncover clients who want virtual coaching services but lack the understanding and experience to determine whether it is an effective solution for their fitness goals. When identifying and discussing options with clients who may benefit from virtual coaching services, it is important to understand that offering virtual coaching services is not an all-or-nothing or one-size-fits-all approach. Instead, it can be used to help facilitate the fitness professional's coach/client relationship, promoting goal attainment while minimizing sales objections.



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The Client Who Prefers to Stay Home

It is no surprise that there are clients who avoid the gym environment due to any number of reasons including long commutes, packed schedules, family commitments, and/or even lack of self-confidence. Regardless of why these individuals do not frequent the gym, it is the responsibility of the fitness professional to overcome these obstacles. The use of virtual coaching can help bridge the gap for individuals who are looking for change but may lack the desire to participate in training or coaching in a gym. No matter the reason, virtual coaching allows these clients to experience the benefits of health and fitness programming with live guidance from a fitness professional.

The Client Who Moved Away

Typically, when a client moves away it ends the client/trainer relationship. However, virtual coaching allows the fitness professional to leverage the virtual environment to continue their relationship through remote training and/or coaching. With a few adjustments to accommodate available space, access to

equipment, and scheduling, clients who move away may find it easier to continue their current programming or coaching sessions versus finding another trainer or coach.

Clients Who Vacation Frequently

Clients who skip training or nutrition coaching sessions on extended vacations often experience a momentum shift and risk derailing the efforts previously made to reach their goals. Virtual coaches can bridge that gap by suggesting live sessions that accommodate equipment and space changes or providing predesigned workouts while clients are on vacation. Depending on the client's goals, these sessions could be lighter than usual, incorporate local activities, and focus more on recovery than progression.

Clients With Demanding Work Schedules

Clients whose professions require shift work or exhaustive work schedules that do not accommodate normal working hours often have difficulty sticking to a schedule, making it hard to provide consistent fitness solutions, whether in-person or virtual. According to the World Health Organization (2020), "adults aged 18-24 should do at least 150 minutes of moderate-intensity aerobic physical activity throughout the week" no matter their work schedule. Because of this, virtual coaching is a great opportunity for those that may not have been able to make the traditional gym hours required for in-person training or coaching work. While working with such clients may require virtual coach to accommodate odd hours for training, the impact could be immense. A 2018 study found that "many shift workers fail to achieve the recommended physical activity guidelines and [,] consequently, the majority of shift workers are insufficiently active" (Flahr et al., 2018).

Global Pandemic Restrictions (COVID-19)

When gyms and health clubs were forced to close due to COVD-19, virtual coaching allowed fitness professionals to quickly pivot to a safe and effective environment, while maintaining or even growing the business. While the fitness industry focused on keeping businesses afloat, health care providers emphasized the connection between physical fitness and recovery from the virus, noting that "exercise may reduce the risk of acute respiratory distress syndrome, a major cause of death in patients with coronavirus disease 2019 (COVID-19)" (Nyenhuis, et al., 2020). This connection reinforces the need for virtual coaching as a means of educating clients on the importance of physical fitness as a part of a comprehensive proactive health management program.

The potential client types and opportunities identified are merely examples of those who may benefit most from virtual coaching. By appropriately identifying and integrating various virtual technologies with specific needs, virtual coaching can benefit just about any client, solidifying the service as one of the most versatile and innovative ways to make an impact on the fitness industry as a professional.

Qualifications for Virtual Coaching

The qualifications of a virtual coach can be interpreted in many ways based on the professional's education and industry experience, as well as the character traits required to sustain success as a virtual coach. Aside from working with clients, it is imperative proper credentials have been obtained to safely and effectively coach clients with various health and fitness goals. Without the foundational knowledge and credentialing in either fitness training and/or nutrition coaching, the risk of client injury and liability is greatly increased. Becoming a virtual coach should help augment the professional's credentials recognized by the fitness industry and is not intended as a substitute.

Fitness Credentials

The transition to virtual coaching should be relatively smooth for an experienced personal trainer or nutrition coach looking to broaden services offered to clients. Although not required, those new to the fitness industry should consider completing the NASM-CPT or NASM-CNC course before venturing into the virtual coaching environment.

Character Traits of a Successful Virtual Coach

A fitness professional's passion for motivating and helping clients to learn, grow, and achieve goals should be evident through virtual coaching strategies. When transitioning or augmenting current services, fitness professionals may face communication challenges such as maintaining appropriate tone and cadence, building rapport, and maintaining a coach–client relationship that encourages accountability. When looking to overcome these challenges, consistency is key.

Having an entrepreneurial spirit is another essential attribute for virtual coaches who look to attract and retain clients while minimizing turnover. The virtual coach's proactive mindset keeps them seeking innovative ways to reach new clients and improve their ability to provide effective coaching. This entrepreneurial mindset can help drive the virtual coach to be creative with marketing, social media presence, networking, referral programs, innovative promotion ideas, and gated content to bring in new clients. Without this continuous drive for creativity and innovation, it becomes increasingly difficult to stand out in the virtual setting.

Scope of Practice

Virtual coaches are expected to adhere to the **scope of practice**, which includes the procedures and processes fitness professionals follow in accordance with their fitness certification.

After evaluating a client's situation thoroughly, honestly, and independently, virtual coaches will be required to determine whether it is safe for the client to provide virtual coaching services or if a referral to an appropriate medical professional is needed. Whether the virtual coach is providing training or nutrition coaching, the scope of practice resides with the credentials carried by the professional. The limitations and boundaries of the coaching services a fitness professional is able to provide can be found within their credentials already obtained. While operating in a virtual environment does not change the scope of practice, it can provide some additional challenges.

Critical!

When offering virtual coaching services to clients, fitness professionals should review the scope of practice limitations and boundaries identified by the credentials earned through the organization or certifying body from which they were obtained. Whether the professional is offering training services or nutrition coaching, offering these services in a virtual format does not change the scope of practice.

Certified Personal Training

Personal trainers looking to use the virtual environment as an additional service for their clients will need to adhere to the scope of practice limitations and boundaries they operate with within their in-person training sessions. Because of the limits of operating virtually, the personal trainer will still be required to identify when it is appropriate to refer the client to a licensed professional.

- Personal trainers do not diagnose injuries. If a client sustains an injury during a training session, the trainer should immediately refer the client to the appropriate licensed medical professional. This protocol is for physical and psychological diagnoses alike.
- Personal trainers do not provide counseling services for past or present. If approached by a client seeking advice for a medical issue or injury, the trainer should immediately refer the client to the appropriate licensed medical professional.

Certified Nutrition Coaching

Professionals with the opportunity to provide nutrition coaching services understand the potential impact on their client's health through their ability to provide education on making healthy choices and promoting positive behavior change. Like the certified personal training professional, nutrition coaches looking to offer virtual services will be required to adhere to their scope of practice and refer out to a licensed professional when necessary.

- Nutrition coaches do not provide meal planning services. If approached by a client requesting meal planning, the nutrition coach should immediately refer the client to a registered dietitian.
- Nutrition coaches do not provide nutritional therapy. If approached by a client seeking nutritional therapy, the nutrition coach should immediately refer the client to the appropriate licensed medical professional.

Scope of practice

The actions that a professional is permitted to undertake in keeping with the terms of her or his license or certification.

Virtual Coaching Obstacles and Challenges

While virtual coaching is a timely solution to an industry-wide problem, fitness professionals should understand and acknowledge the constraints that come with providing virtual services. Compared to in-person services, such as personal training or nutrition coaching, the fitness professional looking to augment their services by offering a virtual option will need to address additional obstacles and challenges faced in the virtual environment. Aside from the technical obstacles and challenges faced when offering virtual coaching, the virtual coach will need to identify and acknowledge that there are differences between interacting in-person versus virtually with the client.



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Client Engagement

A virtual environment makes it easier for clients to disengage, making client retention markedly more difficult for virtual coaches. Therefore, fitness professionals looking to offer virtual services will face new challenges with client engagement. Unlike in-person personal training or nutrition coaching, the virtual coach will need to seek creative solutions to ensure client engagement is upheld consistently throughout each virtual session, not to mention the required commitment for clients to complete offline activities such as forms, logs, etc. Understanding how to gauge and measure a client's engagement as a virtual coach is a crucial skill to providing effective virtual coaching. Because every client engages differently, the virtual coach will need to pay greater attention to how their client reacts to the virtual coaching they are provided.

Client Safety

Like with in-person personal training and nutrition coaching, the client's safety should remain a top priority. When offering virtual services, it is imperative that fitness professionals design programs that prioritize client safety while being conducive to the virtual environment. Because the virtual coach is unable to be with their client, they should continuously assess and address the client when risk of injury is identified during a live session.

When executing a virtual training session with a client, fitness professionals should keep the following in mind to help minimize injury risk:

- Virtual coaches cannot see every angle of the client.
- Virtual coaches cannot act as a spotter and should not provide programming that requires one.
- Virtual coaches should be more diligent about monitoring and correcting form, demonstrating exercises, and watching for safety concerns such as abnormal discomfort.
- Virtual coaches should never assume their clients' abilities.

Critical!

In addition to programming considerations, virtual coaches must be prepared to react quickly, notifying the client's local authorities and/or an emergency contact should something go wrong during the virtual training session. For this reason, each client should provide a street address, emergency contact, and local police department phone number.

Professional Burnout

Working remotely in any profession comes with the challenge of achieving a healthy work–life balance. For fitness professionals who are just beginning with virtual coaching, earning new clients can be exciting; however, packing a schedule with sessions every hour on the hour can quickly lead to burnout. Considering that work and life will probably never be balanced, a 2014 study on the work habits of surgeons suggests the concept of creating a work–life budget.

> *"Just as a budget is made at the beginning of each year for... the home, a budget should be made for work and life. And just as importantly, the budget for work–life balance needs to be individualized to best meet the needs of the individual (Raja & Stein, 2014)."*

That being said, virtual coaches should set working hours while reserving time for personal and professional development. Setting these boundaries can help virtual coaches stay healthy while setting a positive example for clients.

Summary

Virtual coaching allows fitness professionals to serve clients that may have otherwise been out of reach due to their preference, proximity, or availability. On the surface, it seems like the logical next step for every fitness professional, but virtual coaching will not work for everyone. Just as a fitness professional examines a client's needs before assigning a training program, a similar assessment must be completed to determine if adding virtual training is a sound business decision. When determining whether to offer virtual services, fitness professionals should consider the following pros and cons of virtual coaching:



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Pros

- Allows any fitness professional to reach a global audience
- Can be more affordable for clients than in-person training (especially without a gym membership and travel considerations), increasing the potential of acquiring new clients
- More opportunities in geographical locations with few fitness facilities to work at
- Same coach for clients no matter the location, providing the opportunity to build greater, longer lasting client–coach relationships

Cons

- Clients lacking understanding for the value of virtual coaching and preferring in-person training or coaching, making it hard to sell the benefits of virtual services
- Fitness goals requiring the fitness professional to be present with the client to minimize the risk of injury
- Technology obstacles such as Internet connection, device requirements, and technical support sometimes making it difficult to ensure a seamless and effective virtual session
- Allocating appropriate space for virtual sessions challenging for fitness professionals who do not or cannot stage a designated personal training or coaching space in their home

Successful fitness professionals are committed to helping their clients realize the benefits of achieving specific fitness and nutrition goals. When incorporating virtual services into their business model, the fitness professional has the potential of taking this client commitment one step further.

While it may seem that virtual training can take away from the personal and professional experience shared between a coach and client, one can also argue that it does just the opposite. Seeking additional ways to support clients' needs in this way will add to the level of care, understanding, and respect provided as virtual services to clients daily. In addition, there has never been a better (or more workable) time in history to augment the services offered by fitness professionals leveraging a virtual strategy. As technology and online business continues to grow, the normalcy of meeting and conducting business online has become commonplace. Having the knowledge and skills to offer virtual solutions at a global scale is not only lucrative and smart for the growing professional, but also incredibly beneficial for clients who otherwise would not have the opportunity to engage in traditional coaching.

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